

THE QUEEN AND THE COMMONER

Volatile partings, suicide attempts, panic attacks. The Dutt romance was worthy of the movies.



DARLINGJI: THE TRUE LOVE STORY OF NARGIS AND SUNIL DUTT

by KISHWAR DESAI

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■ By Kaveree Bamzai

It is astonishing that an affair between a married actor and his leading lady, which ran its course 50 years ago, should still fascinate us literally and cinematically. Perhaps because it was as seductive as it was tarnished—she was an independent-minded single woman, he was the father of four children; she was Muslim and he was Hindu; she was the daughter of a low-born singer, he was the son of an acting legend. But when it comes to Raj Kapoor and Nargis, the drama refuses to end. Kishwar Desai's account, *Darlingji: The True Love Story of Nargis and Sunil Dutt*, borrowing liberally from her diaries and letters, is ostensibly about Mr and Mrs Dutt but expectedly Desai cannot write about it without closing the chapter with Kapoor. Perhaps for the first time ever, and this is significant because many words have already been expended on Kapoor and Nargis, the book shows us Nargis's determined break from the man and the banner she had come to be identified with.

It couldn't have been easy for her to end it with a handshake, rather than hand-wringing. She was not only Kapoor's lover, one who would go out for drives in his car with actor Nimmi in the backseat as subterfuge and one who had even gone to the then home minister Morarji Desai asking to be married to him, but also his co-worker in building RK Films. When Nargis and Sunil Dutt met on the sets of *Mother India* and fell in love after he rescued her from a fire, she was the celebrity, one who had had a famous relationship, and what's more, was playing Dutt's mother in a film directed by the Great Dictator, Mehboob Khan, who did not want news of their affair to ruin the marketability of his classic.



STARS APART: Nargis's brutal honesty was not always matched by a struggling Dutt

EXCERPTS

Ameena came back with the news that Sunil had gone out of town. Nargis nearly collapsed. She bought a bottle of sleeping pills and planned to drug herself every day. If there was no news from him, she would swallow the final, lethal overdose. Unable to resist his own feelings, he called her. The sleeping pills were thrown out as Nargis packed quickly to go to him next morning. Their reunion was long and intense. But he wanted her to know exactly what distressed her. He even ticked her off for behaving "like an actress" when other men were around, casually reclining on a sofa at home or cracking "filthy jokes" which burnt his ears. In Sunil's book this was unacceptable. If she had to tell dirty jokes, it had better be only to him.

There were even more important, career-enhancing invitations she refused. She would tell Sunil later, "I got a letter from America inviting me to be present for the Oscars—I said I couldn't go. I didn't tell you these things for you to develop complexes." On March 4, when she least expected it, she received a letter from Sunil which was like a body blow. She wrote back to him: "Oh! Jio again—those sharp words that cut me through and through. 'My dear Padma Shri' this is how you started and ended it with 'A Jr Artiste'. You made that noise because I didn't tell you about the Filmfare award. I never used to hide anything—till you yourself said I should not tell you these things as they can create complexes in your mind."